assassination. He, therefore, sought the help of the laboratory to develop the film roll and print copies for the crime branch. Chandrasekharan's deputy, Watson, made copies and printed them—a set of ten photographs.

One of the photographs showed a bespectacled woman wearing a green-and-orange salwar kameez, carrying a sandalwood garland. Another woman and a teenage girl could also be seen, and a white kurta-pyjama-clad man standing a little away from them. Chandrasekharan took the chance of a lifetime. He gave a copy of the photograph to Special Correspondent Prakash Swamy of *The Hindu*, who had tagged along with Chandrasekharan since morning and was present in his office even at that point of time. The forensics expert thought its publication would inspire people to volunteer information about the people in the photograph.

The forensics laboratory started working at full steam. It pieced together what appeared to be the explosive device that was used to assassinate Rajiv Gandhi. They found pieces of tattered blue denim cloth with electrical wires attached to them and bits and pieces of the green-and-orange salwar kameez that the bespectacled woman was wearing in the photograph. They matched what was still found attached to the dismembered female body at the morgue earlier. This was followed by DNA tests, and it appeared that the female was a human bomb that killed Rajiv. This was a first in Indian history.

While Chandrasekharan was congratulated by all and sundry for his breakthrough, the SIT was desperately trying to find out the identity of those in the photograph and their antecedents. During the interrogation of those who had attended Rajiv's rally at Sriperumbudur, one woman identified the two females in one of the pictures taken by Haribabu and claimed she had seen them mingling with the 'human bomb' and the white-kurta-pyjama-clad man seen in Haribabu's first picture. The two girls were later found to be Nalini and the second human bomb, Shubha.

But why had Chandrasekharan given the photograph to a newspaper before sharing it with the investigators? His reply was through a counter-question to Anirudhya. 'Did it hamper the investigation or help the investigation at a time when the CBI was clueless about which direction to